tions of the same (FYI, 4=A if you're substituting numbers for letters).

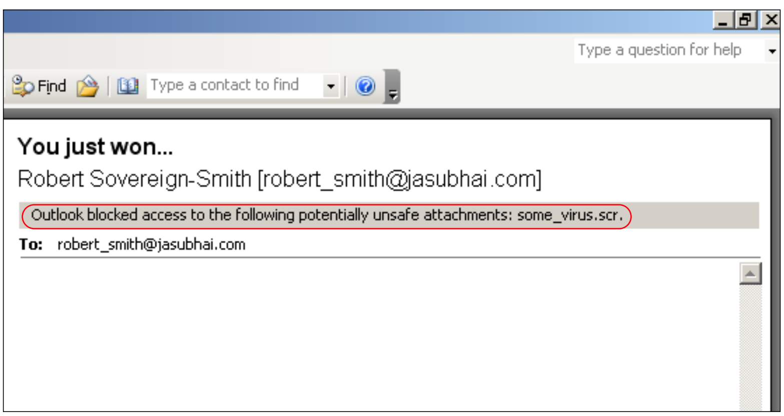
Sometimes people are complacent and set their passwords to their mother's, spouse's or pet's name. These should be easy for anyone who knows you well enough to guess, and are thus a bad idea. Using your date of birth is also a big no-no. An example of a good password would be "R4o!s!nD4h0u53" (Rao is in da house) using numbers, letters and an exclamation mark! You could even set a cryptic enough hint to this password, such as "All Hail me...I have arrived".

We should reiterate that a lot of intrusions and security lapses happen only because of weak passwords.

Networks

This is perhaps the biggest boon and bane of the IT world! If we all had standalone computers, we would have no security problems. At the same time, we wouldn't have PCs in the first place then anyway! Networks have brought us everything we now take for granted: the Internet, ATMs, LANs, Wi-Fi, hackers, viruses, spam... you get the picture.

Your office LAN is where most of the attacks come from. Whether it's from your colleagues or from an unknown hacker across the world who has got into one system and is trying to explore the network. A virus on one colleague's PC could infect an entire office if you don't take basic security seriously. Things like anti-virus software are now a given, and no office is without one, but what about anti-spam software? And what about anti-adware or anti-spyware software?



Beware of e-mail attachments—especially those with EXE, ZIP, SCR and PIF extensions

Most offices are vulnerable via e-mail, and that oh-so-cute PowerPoint presentation you received in a mail might just contain a new Trojan that your anti-virus knows nothing about. So think twice (or two hundred times) before you blindly forward it to your entire office—or perhaps you should consider not opening these things at work in the first place.

Sharing is another hassle. Some of us learn of dollar shares, and think, "ahh, perfect!" We then promptly share important stuff with a dollar at the end of the name and then tell our bosses where to find them. Unfortunately, dollar shares are far from secure. Just because you haven't told anyone the name of the shared folder doesn't mean people will not find your shares. For example, anyone on a Linux computer can find your shares just by browsing through the network. Windows users, too, have several small software, available for free download, that can scan a LAN to find computers and their shared folders—simple shares or dollar shares.

So it could be someone looking for some new music that accidentally stumbles across your shared folder that contains your team's appraisal sheet, or data meant only for your boss to see! In such cases, perhaps the internal e-mail system would be much more prudent to use.

Of course the risks are increased by orders of magnitude when you have a wireless LAN, since you not only have to worry about the users in your office, you also have to worry about guests and people outside. A good site plan when setting up a Wi-Fi network is a must, and good security should be used—like 128-bit encryption at access points. Make sure you have access lists set by MAC addresses, and that you supply users with fixed IP addresses, rather than using the Dynamic Host Controller Protocol (DHCP), where IP addresses are assigned upon connection.

Read up on Wi-Fi networking and make sure to follow all security measures properly, or else you could get intruders in your LAN. The damage could be as simple as increased bandwidth due to unauthorised client PCs accessing the Internet, or as severe as data being corrupted and going missing, or even company secrets and policies being stolen. *Digit*'s book *Fast Track to Wi-Fi*, provided with the May 2005 issue, should tell you more about Wi-Fi security.

Finalising Security

For companies that base their marketing on the level of security their data has, a good thing to do is ISO certification. For information security and management, you should look to get your company ISO-17799 certified. (See box *Proper Policies*).

Since getting this certification will most certainly be expensive, smaller companies might not want to opt for such drastic measures. That's where scouring the Net for information on security policies and reading up on case studies of companies with proper security training techniques will help you.

Remember, your company's security is only as strong as the weakest link, which most often is at the executive level. So make sure you train your employees well. We've just given you a refresher in the basics, mainly due to the fact that every business has its own individual security requirements.

Online businesses, for example, need a way to secure their Web server and databases. Offline businesses will have a security requirement for their accounts and offline databases. Who has access to what information, and who uses which computer, is something your company security policy needs to decide. BPOs need to limit the amount and type of data that different levels of employees access; the list is endless.

Once you figure out what data needs to be kept secure, you can start looking for security loopholes and then decide upon a strategy to plug them all up. Meanwhile, you can start at the lowest level by teaching your employees about the necessity of personal data security. ⊠

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